

were invited to meet Cyrus, but find him not present. His name was announced at the door, but by mistake. We were promised sight of the Babylonian exiles, but they have failed to put in an appearance. It turns out that the banquet was an afterthought, not authorized. See the next chapter.

Second Isaiah is indeed a prophecy of release from bondage and a triumphant return of 'exiles' to Jerusalem by sea and land; but the prophet is looking to the ends of the earth, not to Babylonia. There is indeed prediction, definite and many times repeated, of the speedy advent of a great conqueror and deliverer, the restorer of Israel and benefactor of the world; but the prophet is speaking of the Anointed Servant of the Lord, the Son of David, not the son of Cambyses.

CHAPTER III

THE CYRUS-BABYLON INTERPOLATIONS

It has been shown in the preceding chapters that the attempt to explain Second Isaiah as a prophecy addressed to the deported Jews in Babylonia breaks down completely and ends in chaos. The occurrence of the names "Cyrus, Babylon, Chaldea" in passages of obviously central significance claims for the poems a very definite situation and intention. In each instance, however, the claim is belied by the immediate context (a startling fact), while the effort to maintain it throughout even one of the chapters concerned is found fruitless, necessitating excisions and emendations of a well-attested text. There is hardly a single poem in the postulated literary unit 40-55 which can be forced into the required historical situation, and even after the scissors have been courageously applied our commentators must "lament the inconsistencies" of the prophet. He persistently loses sight of the thing he is supposed to be saying; while employing the same phrases which had seemed to mark him as 'the Prophet of the Exile' he deals with ideas quite incongruous with the situation in Babylonia and the year 540; in every single instance where he has seemed to be indulging in extravagant utterances regarding the Persian king there is more than a suspicion that he has in mind a greater and more enduring factor in the history of mankind. It is clear that he believes himself to be uttering things of great importance, not for Israel only but for all the world; our commentators easily show this to be a delusion.

There is something wrong here, and it will presently be seen that the trouble is not deep-seated, but purely an external matter. By a few slight touches here and there in well-chosen places it is possible to disguise any human face. By a similar process new and misleading features have been added to many ancient documents, since the time when interpreters first began to demand (and achieve) certainty in place of ambiguity, and propagandists to seek documentary authority for their views.

We have here before us what is doubtless the most important example of such disguise in all the history of literature. With the half-dozen slight but potent touches removed, we see one of the

greatest men of antiquity, and an unsurpassed creation of religious philosophy and poetry, without blemish or ambiguity. While the transforming touches remain, the 'prophet' is a forlorn figure, and his work is *tohu* and *bohu*. Confusion and incoherence are substituted for order and logical consistency, very extensive interpolation and editorial adjustment must be supposed, and the whole work is largely emptied of ethical value. Its second half (a succession of magnificent poems!) is of necessity ascribed to an inferior imitator, or to a school of imitators, no one of whom clearly understood either his own message or that of the predecessors whose phrases and figures of speech he copied.*

It is now in place to examine the Hebrew text of the passages which contain mention of the foreign king by name and evident reference to Babylonia as the land to be conquered by him and thereupon to be abandoned by Jewish exiles returning to Jerusalem. The ancient versions support the Hebrew; no argument against the traditional reading can be derived from any one of them, in any of the passages to be considered. If the original text has suffered alteration or received addition, the 'improvement' was made before the time when the work of translation into Greek was undertaken. There is, however, other and most important evidence, quite aside from the general literary considerations. The *meter* of the poems affords a criterion of which the value is universally recognized.

Emendation on the basis of metric form is now a commonplace of textual criticism, and wherever meter and internal evidence plainly support each other against the traditional reading the argument is justly regarded as conclusive. There is need of great caution here (see Chapter X), but valid evidence is to be had. Very many passages in the poetical portions of the Hebrew Bible have thus been restored to their original form, with the approval of all competent scholars. The Hebrew text of II Isaiah is generally well preserved, a fact which is of great assistance in an investigation of this nature. The present problem, moreover, is in fact simpler than appears at first sight. It can easily be shown that the whole question of the interpolation of Babylonian-exilic allusions hangs upon the single word *lē-Kōresh*, "to Cyrus," in 45:1. On this depends also the decision as to the meaning and value of the prophecy of the Second Isaiah. If the prophet himself wrote here

* If the reader supposes this to be an exaggerated statement, it is only necessary to refer him to any one of the modern standard commentaries. See also the concluding section of Chapter I in this volume.

the name of the Persian king, then the low estimate of the man and the utter confusion wrought in the book, as set forth in Chapter I, are inevitable. If he did not write it, then the whole modern theory of his book, with the tissue of contradictions and the chimera of a 'Trito-Isaiah,' is gone in a twinkling. It will be seen, when the passages are examined, that the 'Cyrus-exile' element is present only in a few small and purely superficial spots, dabbed on, as it were, in an easy-going way by some one who felt that he could render a useful service by making plain what was obscure. When the spots are removed—and they come off very easily, leaving no mark—the *meter of each passage is for the first time in order*, and there remains in the whole prophecy no suggestion either of Jews in Babylonia or of a foreign potentate.

1. The "Cyrus" Interpolations in 45:1 and 44:28

It has already been shown, in Chapter II, how terms definitely applied by the prophet to *Israel*, as God's 'elect,' the one who was 'called from the ends of the earth,' 'whose right hand God holds,' who is to 'perform all his pleasure,' who is to 'thresh mountains, and make the hills as chaff,' scattering all foes like a whirlwind, are in 45:1 ff. applied to *Cyrus*; and if in this passage, then presumably in others—with confusion as the result. Logically, all these passages should refer to the same chosen instrument of God's purpose; in fact, they cannot possibly all be made to refer to Cyrus, and the attempt to fit them to him necessitates in every case some slight alteration of the text. Do they not, then, all refer to Israel, or Israel's representative? Has the mention of Cyrus by name a place in the Hebrew text which is above suspicion?

There are probably not many who realize how strong is the merely textual evidence against the word *lě-Kōresh*, "to Cyrus," in 45:1. The fact is, it is metrically superfluous, and so distinctly so, that this one fact is sufficient of itself to mark it as a probable interpolation. The metric verse originally read as follows:

kōh āmār Yahwē limēšichō, | āšēr hechēzāqtī bimānō.

To one who glances at Professor Cheyne's edition of the Hebrew, where the text is printed in metric lines, the length of this particular line, with the name added, cannot fail to attract attention. There is nothing else like it on the whole page; all the other lines are of about the same length, but the one word *lě-Kōresh* projects beyond the margin, and stares the reader in the face. When the

attempt is made to scan the passage, the superfluous name is even more troublesome. As poetry, the line is ruined by the presence of this word; the fact is beyond question. In Kittel's *Biblia Hebraica*, it is relegated to the second half of the verse, but with no improvement in the result. Neither in the first half-verse nor in the second half can the word find a place.

The conclusion, supported by such evidence, internal and external, ought to be no longer in doubt; the word is an *explanatory addition to the text*, by a later hand; its office being to interpret the word *limēšichō*, "to his anointed one."

Some one, it seems, saw in our poet's frequent songs of exultation promising "deliverance to captives," predictions of the return from the Babylonian exile, and wished to make them more definite. This was in every way most natural. More than half of the book is taken up with assurances of speedy help and release for down-trodden Israel. The 'exiled' children of Zion are to return. The former glory of Jerusalem, the holy city, now desolate, shall speedily be restored. The wasted cities of Judah shall be built up, and the faithful people of God shall again possess them. Strangers and enemies are to have the upper hand no longer in the sacred territory. God has been cherishing his great purpose, and will now show the nations his power. He is on the point of raising up a great deliverer, who shall trample upon the heathen nations, and bring release to the chosen people. He shall "raise up the tribes of Jacob, and restore Israel."

The prophet also predicts in a very striking manner the downfall and destruction of Babylon. In the fine poem which constitutes chapter 47 he rebukes at length (for the only time) the arrogant wickedness of a portion of the Gentile world, so mighty and prosperous, in contrast with Israel, and of course admired and envied by very many of the prophet's fellow countrymen. Babylon had long been for the Hebrew people of Palestine the symbol of worldly power, luxury, and pride. As such a symbol the great metropolis and former capital is presented and denounced in this poem. Nothing is said, indeed, of her present *power*; the picture is rather of pampered selfishness and of a contemptuous reliance on her own deities and enchanters—on her own 'wisdom.' She is soon to be brought to the dust, says the prophet, and her sages and sorcerers will feel the fire of hell. The worthlessness of her 'great gods' will be patent to the world. In all the poem there is not even a hint at any 'Babylonian captivity' of Jews, nor of any benefit which Israel is to receive from the fall of the city; and yet